AP Research Paper

Tracking & Managing Mental Health

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Introduction:

As time goes by, so does the amount of mental health conditions that go untreated. According to the National Alliance on Mental Illnesses (NAMI), approximately 1 in 5 adults in the U.S. in a given year, where 50% of all lifetime cases of mental illness begin developing by age 14 (NAMI). The transition between high school and college is a well know time of stress as students adapt to a new chapter in their lives and when new diagnoses may emerge. The accessibility for students to find resources within their college regarding their mental health is vital for academic success and wellness. However, it's also important that students use these resources. Scientific research shows that there is a strong correlation between fewer students using available resources because of the stigmas surrounding mental health.

Research Question:

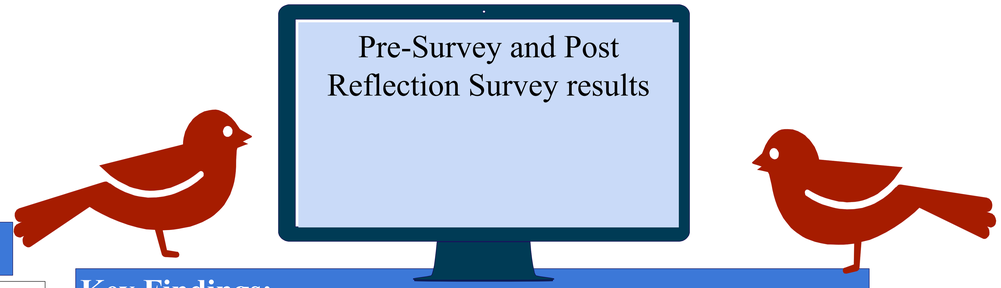
Would a free website design—that includes mood, sleep, diet, stress, and exercise,—encourage mental health critical thinking and empower adolescents to seek additional help when needed?

Methods:

In this experiment, participants aged 14-24 years old would use the website I designed to track their diet, mood,stress level, exercise, and sleep. Participants were asked to try at least two features of the application each day. However, they must have tried all variables within the application. The purpose of this research is to determine the most effective variables included in a mental health tracker. Analyzing the correlation that behaviors have with their physical and mental health is essential. For instance, research shows that sleep deprivation is linked to higher cortisol levels, which play a significant role in stress and demonstrates a strong correlation with weight gain (CDC, 2014). A participant can analyze first hand how their sleep may affect their stress level. On average, participants indicated that tracking took about 5 minutes each day.







Key Findings:

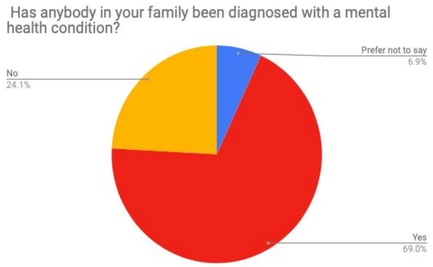


Figure 3 The percentage of participants reporting a family member with a mental health diagnosis.

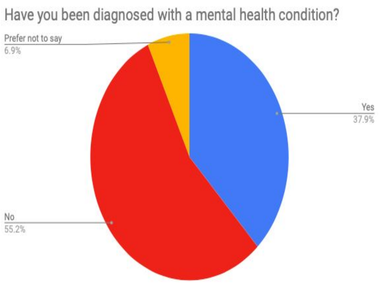


Figure 2 The percentage participants anonymously reporting a mental health diagnosis.

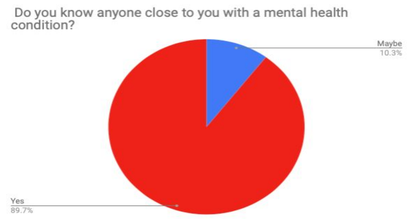


Figure 5 Percentage of participants in the study saying they know someone with a mental health condition or someone who is currently undiagnosed but believes they have a mental health condition.

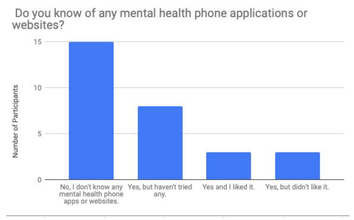


Figure 8 The number of participants that have heard, tried, and liked a mental health phone application or website.

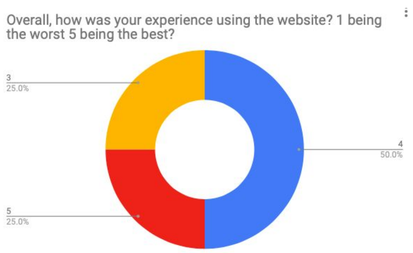


Figure 10 Percentage of participants rating their experience with the mental health tracker on a 1 to 5 Likert scale.

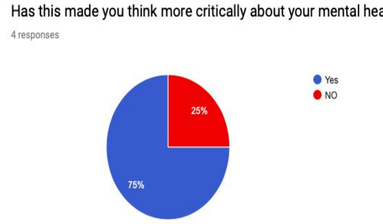


Figure 11 Percentage of participants saying whether the website made them think more critically about their mental health.

There is a high frequency of participants who don't discuss about their mental health with parents on a regular basis then friends and non-parental figures in general. Despite a high percentage mental health diagnosis among participants and family members, more than 70% of participants don't have an approach to tracking their mental health. On average, those who completed the post-reflection survey marked their experience with my website as a 4. Additionally, 75% said it made them think more critically about their mental health. Interestingly enough, only one of the 4 correspondents indicated that there experience led them to make changes in their habits and consider speaking to their friends about their mental health.

Conclusion

By analyzing the post-reflection results, it can be reasoned that a majority of adolescents did think more critically about their mental health by tracking their behaviors. However, it wasn't enough for them to change their habits within two weeks. The question, " How long until participants will change their habits?" is not just applicable to this study, but rather to other forms of mental health management. For instance, cognitive behavioral therapy is a well-known form of mental health management that aims to improve self-management through physical communication and explaining good habits. Treatments usually last 50 minutes a week but vary depending on the patient. Likewise, results aren't expected to be seen quickly. Therefore, it would be of interest for future researchers to investigate the time quantity for individuals tracking behaviors online and how it compares to an individual in therapy.

Recommendation:

I suggest that future studies account for the knowledge required to design a website that requires database storage from the start. Lastly, my results raise questions such as, "how would the user experience been if the participants were selected based on whether they have all not talked about their mental health with others? Would tracking their behaviors lead them to take action more quickly than those who already have a strong mental health support group?"

Definitions

1) **Mental Health Services**- Public private, or college offered services that assesses diagnosis, treat, or counsel.
2) **Depression**- Persistent feeling of sadness
3) **Insomnia** - Sleep deprivation or persistent problems falling asleep and staying asleep for 7 or more hours (the minimum recommended amount of hours for an adult).
4) **Mental Health College services**- Free resources that the college provides within the campus.
5) **Community Interactions**- A place in an application where an individual may anonymously talk to others or ask questions.

Acknowledgements:

I would like to thank Mrs. Lawrance, Mr. Brozowski, and the RDU Desk Center for helping me develop the website. Additionally, I would like to thank Dr.Sikes for being my research mentor.